

## Portrait of a Writing Master: Beyond the Myth of Marianne Moore

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Among the many odd animals found in Marianne Moore's poetry, perhaps the most surprising is a dragon. Equally surprising is Moore's uncharacteristically straightforward admission that she would like to be a dragon, "of silkworm size or immense," perhaps "almost invisible" but a decidedly "felicitous phenomenon." That dragon is a clue to the person behind the tame exterior which Marianne Moore constructed for herself by means of her poetry. As the centennial of Moore's birth approaches and critics begin to reassess her work, the importance of the dragon must emerge. Unlike the unicorn—equally fabulous but shrouded in mystery, and symbolic of meditative companionship—the dragon is a fighter, a serpent, and in mythic terms, an insatiable warrior. It is surprising, therefore, that some of Moore's critics have for so long treated her as a decorative oddity rather than as an active, perhaps even dangerous force. To a great extent, the blame for this misperception lies with Moore herself. Discussion of the origin of the misleading myth of Marianne Moore and its history is the concern of this essay. Moore's poetry itself is the source of the myth. New Criticism is the agent of its installation as fact. But Moore provides evidence which exposes and counteracts the myth. Part of this evidence is Moore's own private papers and letters which have only recently been made available. They reveal Moore's methodical ambition and unshakable determination, and show that her discipline was tempered by humorous irony. The portraits Moore's friends drew in their memoirs of the period provide other evidence which reinforces

this complex, formidable image. All the evidence permits us to see beyond the popular myth.

Although the opening line of "The Pangolin"—"Another armored animal"<sup>1</sup>—certainly seems tinged with self-directed irony, there is ample evidence throughout Moore's poetry to support a straightforward reading which accepts the confession of timidity at face value and locates Moore hiding defensively behind a protective covering. In "The Fish" brittle scales turn invasive light back upon itself. In "Melancthon" thick skin serves as an impermeable barrier. In "The Steeple-Jack," the geometry of Moore's frozen seaside scene seems impervious. The perfection of her landscape protects the town's residents from any recognition of danger. The examples are innumerable, but the poems are, of course, not quite so simple. Moore's first critics recognized the extent to which she tried to emphasize rather than diminish contradiction, and much recent criticism is turning back to that point of view. Nevertheless, at least one ongoing perception of Marianne Moore fails to recognize Moore's complexity and the depth of her deliberate ambiguity. This misperception is to a large extent the result of the popular image of Marianne Moore—one which she herself constructed. The image gains power from the contrast between Moore's radically experimental poetry and her conventional, ordinary life. Kenneth Burke attributes the incongruity of Moore's extraordinary intelligence and her ordinary life to her obsessive attention to detail. On occasion, he reports, she would be nearly overcome by the visual stimuli in a museum. Well aware of the unusual intensity of her powers of observation and her reaction to stimuli, Moore tried, Burke says, to diminish an outsider's recognition of her impressionability and sensitivity. She was not, however, always successful. "She tried so hard to be ordinary," Burke says, "that she became even more extraordinary."<sup>2</sup>

It is, in fact, the intention to be ordinary that distinguishes Moore from her fellow moderns. T. S. Eliot's morning coat formality, Ezra Pound's cultivated outlandishness, and the liberated modernism of such female contemporaries as Mina Loy and Djuna Barnes all stand in sharp contrast to Moore's carefully cultivated and presented image of herself. Her personal life seems almost a nineteenth-century anachronism taking place in the bohemian setting of Greenwich Village in the 1920s. Following her graduation from Bryn Mawr College, she lived with her mother until Mrs. Moore's death in 1947. She was as formal in dress as T. S. Eliot, though her tricorne hat and long, black cape did not appear until quite late in her public life. The portraits of

Moore's mother as moralistic and overbearing also seem to be accurate. These particulars are, however, only part of the picture, and the limited even biased portrait they produce works ultimately as a disservice to Moore. T. S. Eliot's formality becomes one indication of his greatness and even helps to define the essence of twentieth-century modernism. Moore's formality remains an idiosyncrasy, a mark of her charming femininity. It has served to keep her at the perimeter rather than at the center of modernism.

An archaeological tour of the ways in which literary critics have read Moore's poetry reveals that they depend more and more over the years on the myth of Marianne Moore. Moore's contemporaries, to begin with, admired her poetry and envied her ambition. They recognized her quaint manner and habits but did not incorporate those qualities into critical readings of her work. In subsequent years, however, Moore's mannerisms came to influence her critics. This occurs, ironically, just at the time when critics began arguing for rigorously analytical treatments of literature. R. P. Blackmur appears to be a turning point. In 1935 he insisted upon an approach which "treats of nothing in literature except in its capacity of reduction to literary fact."<sup>3</sup> He also explained that "in making a formal approach to Marianne Moore" one needs "special terms and special adjustments to meet the texture and pattern of the poems."<sup>4</sup> Blackmur's treatment of Moore is careful and perceptive, but his reading of "Marriage" violates his own critical principles. Calling it a poem "never concerned with either love or lust" (p. 84), he contends that "No poet has been so chaste" (p. 85). When Blackmur goes on to explain that Moore's work presents a "special chastity aside from the flesh," he reveals a predisposition toward her work which results in a circular condemnation of her poetry. "In Miss Moore," according to Blackmur, "life is remote . . . and everything is done to keep it remote" (p. 85). This sensibility "predicted her poetic method; and the defect of her method, in its turn, only represents the idiosyncrasy of her sensibility: that it, like its subject matter, constitutes the perfection of standing aside" (p. 86). Later critics move further away from the core of Moore's poetry and concentrate instead on the ways in which it fails to satisfy their own criteria for good modernist poetry. John Crowe Ransom found Moore's "free verse" to have "little formal clarity" and called it "a break in the poetic style book that has done service for so long."<sup>5</sup> Missing the excitement of the break and its importance in the history of modern poetry, Ransom attempts merely to "identify the precise moment of her discontinuity and so at least reduce it to a minimum" (p. 136). Much of the same is true for studies

which followed Ransom's and found Moore's poetry to be "essentially uncommitted,"<sup>6</sup> "a gesture of fastidiousness,"<sup>7</sup> "not especially modern, not of the twentieth century,"<sup>8</sup> and the tame product of "the orderly world of 'benevolent conclusiveness' that Moore feels safest in."<sup>9</sup> The image of Moore as a quaint anachronism has also produced readings which inexplicably contradict themselves. In *A Homemade World*, Hugh Kenner places Moore along with Pound, Williams, Stevens, Hemingway, Fitzgerald, and Zukofsky into the select group of writers who "rethought and altered, perhaps permanently, the novel and especially the poem."<sup>10</sup> But in describing what he imagines to be Moore's specific contribution, Kenner sees her as little more than a twentieth-century amanuensis. Calling Moore the poet of the typewriter, Kenner explains that "we discern Miss Moore being a librarian, an editor, a teacher of typewriting; locating fragments already printed; picking and choosing; making letter by letter, neat pages" (p. 98).

Recent criticism has begun to question the validity of evaluating Moore's poetry according to traditional New Critical standards. Feminist critics champion Moore as an independent spirit but find that Moore does not fit easily into standard feminist readings. In *Shakespeare's Sisters*, Moore receives only token mention as a twentieth-century modernist whose chief accomplishment is having created a poetry of silences. Suzanne Juhasz, in *Modern American Poetry by Women*, goes much further by championing Moore as one of the greatest American poets. Juhasz, however, laments Moore's severely curtailed, if not nonexistent romantic life. Juhasz feels that the absence of sexual relationships limits the range of Moore's poetry. In addition to these feminist readings of Moore and others which are now in progress, critical theorists have turned to Moore's work and recognized her complex designs as playful tools. Geoffrey Hartman pairs Moore with Hegel and Derrida; Frank Lentricchia discusses Moore's poetry in the context of other modern poetry; and Marjorie Perloff includes Moore in her study of the relationship between early William Carlos Williams and contemporary avant-garde poetry.

These studies by feminists, critical theorists, and postmodernists reject the popular Moore stereotype and discover instead ways in which Marianne Moore substantiates particular critical stances. Recent full-length studies of Moore, while less polemical, continue to combat the myth of Marianne Moore by refusing to acknowledge its existence. Laurence Stapleton's *The Poet's Advance* emphasizes Moore's wit and takes some account of her private papers. Bonnie Costello's *Imaginary Possessions* goes on to develop a thorough reading of Moore's chief

images. Moore's unpublished notebooks lead Costello to some of the fullest readings of Moore's poetry that have yet been published. Moore, the timid, frightened lady in the black hat, does not exist for Costello. She has been replaced by a poet whose most persuasive images are those of combat and warfare.

While it is heartening to see that the myth has been discarded as useless by some of Moore's critics and has been put aside in favor of more timely and flattering appropriations by theoretical critics, it is important not to ignore the evidence Moore herself provided to engender the myth. It quickly becomes clear that control is, indeed, the subject of Moore's poetry. Many critics automatically see this quality as hermetic and unfortunate. In fact, the control is the product of Moore's limitless ambition, a force as controlled and controlling as the "spruce cone regularity" which she admired in the armored scales of "The Pangolin." But by organizing daily experience and personal circumstance in the enabling forms of her control, Moore created a poetry as personal and emotional as it sometimes seems distant. Moore's poems frequently glorify passionate intensity and seek out chaos and danger. Her pangolin is another armored animal, but it is one with "everlasting vigor, / power to grow." The pangolin thus becomes one version of "the self, the being we call human, writing- / master to this world" (p. 120).

Like a dutiful writing master, Moore meticulously documented her progress toward becoming one. Her record of that progress now provides us with evidence for an alternate view of the poet herself. Moore was a voracious reader and a dedicated record keeper. She saved family letters, reading and appointment notebooks, letters from acquaintances, and carbon copies of her responses to those letters, as well as manuscripts and drafts of her published and unpublished work and even records of her revisions. This material forms a remarkably detailed and complete record of Moore's intellectual and professional development, particularly for the early years of her career. During that time, Moore prepared herself to be both a critic and a poet. She considered everything, regardless of source or chronology, potentially appropriate material for her writing. The manuscripts document her breadth of reference and her use of fragmentary quotations, but more importantly they show that these practices were lifelong habits, part of her conscious preparation for a public career.

Moore's habit of reading and recording grew out of a long-standing family habit of voluminous letter writing. Thus, the documentation of Marianne Moore's adult life begins to emerge in a

remarkable series of letters written between 1905 and 1909, while Moore was a student at Bryn Mawr College. A round in the letters began several times a week with a letter from Mrs. Moore at her home in Carlisle, Pennsylvania. She sent it to Moore's older brother, Warner, who read it, sometimes wrote one of his own, and sent both to Marianne at Bryn Mawr. Moore then wrote a letter and sent all three back to Carlisle. Although the series did not always progress in this manner, most of the letters still exist and provide a detailed record of the family during this period. In them, the family address one another by pet names, many of them drawn from *The Wind in the Willows*. Mrs. Moore was Bunny Fawn or Mole, Warner was Badger, and Marianne, Mice or Rat. The names suggest a playful intimacy, and the letters sometimes display that. More frequently, however, they are characterized by Mrs. Moore's attempts to organize her children's lives and to encourage them to be ambitious. In November, 1908, during Moore's senior year, Mrs. Moore wrote her daughter that in spite of the financial struggle her education represented, "the thing all important this year in regard to Bryn Mawr is that you get the most out of it—that it will yield intellectually and socially."<sup>11</sup> Apparently Moore agreed wholeheartedly. In a letter written on her twenty-first birthday, Moore records with the attention to detail that would characterize much of her later work and with a curious dispassion, just how she was progressing in her schoolwork.<sup>12</sup> After thanking the family for their birthday gifts—a skirt, a box of figs, and a book of Yeats's poetry—she describes her activities for the week. In addition to studying, playing hockey, and attending a play which her classmates had produced, Moore was planning for the future. Her ideas reveal both the discipline and the enthusiasm which would characterize all of her later work. The control of the writing master is already at work.

Writing is too much in line with my natural excesses for me to experiment with it ad libitum so I decided to waive pence and glory and resign from the *Tip* [Bryn Mawr's literary magazine]—as a reward of merit, if I get good marks in February, I shall ask to be let into the imitative writing course. They read all the nineteenth-century books and criticize as much as they write which I think I should like.

Moore concludes the letter with her account of a sermon she had heard that day—a Tuesday—at church. "An Episcopalian from East Orange preached. He said discouragement was egotism."

Moore seems to have taken this message to heart. The pattern of hard work and academic achievement which her mother had en-

couraged and which Marianne records in the college letters continues to be a part of her life. After graduating from Bryn Mawr, Moore returned to Carlisle where she attended Carlisle Commercial College and later taught at the United States Indian School. During that period, Moore continued her education on her own. She recorded much of the process in a form less public and conscious than the letters, in which she was always aware of an audience, if of only two people. Beginning in 1916, just after she published her first poems in *Poetry* and *The Egoist*, Moore began keeping a series of reading and conversation notebooks which she continued throughout her life. They supplement the picture of Moore's industry and meticulous record keeping, and they reveal a good bit about her creative method. Most importantly, as a clue to Moore's intellectual biography, they show that her idiosyncratic interests were a private matter rather than a public affectation. Much like commonplace books, the notebooks contain quotations from Moore's reading and almost no comments of her own. Far from being strictly literary, Moore's sources range from Bertrand Russell's *Introduction to Mathematical Philosophy* and critical studies of contemporary authors, to museum catalogues, *Vogue* magazine, and *Boy's Life*. She covered nearly every inch of the notebooks in microscopic handwriting, indicating the source and often the page number of every reference. But the most remarkable feature of these notebooks is Moore's inclusion at the end of each volume of a complete index according to the author, title, and subject of her entries. It is impossible to determine whether Moore knew how she would eventually use these indexes in composing poems, but they are now valuable for what they show not only about the almost incredible range of her interests but about her creative method as well. For instance, Moore's notebooks contain numerous references to the animals which appear throughout her poetry. In the index to her first reading notebook, for instance, she lists under the heading "animals," "albino snakes, black bear, blacks and wrens at Pan, crocodiles in Palestine, crows, frigate birds, giraffe, grizzly bear, elephants," and a number of other animals. In composing poems she used her notes for finding quotations, probably by relying first on memory and then on a notebook's index. Thus, one poem might contain quotations which she had discovered and recorded on several occasions, often years apart. What caught Moore's attention varied from a single vivid image or a point of information, such as a passage she might record from Darwin's *Variations of Plants and Animals under Domestication*, to one on any subject which caught her eye because of its phrasing or humor. This appreciation of phrasing was the case,

also, with her conversation notebooks, collections of quotations, often by her mother, but just as frequently phrases from an exchange overheard by chance in public. In both instances, Moore kept the records for her own pleasure and information. The practice becomes another indication of the private side of Moore's industry and the methodical nature of her work.

A more public side of Moore's ambition emerged when she traveled to New York to meet some of the young writers who were living there. Once again, she preserved a careful record of her endeavor, this time in a series of letters to her brother. First Moore outlines her preparations for the undertaking. A series of three letters then recounts every detail of the visit, calling it her "Sojourn into the Whale." Parts of the first letter, in which Moore writes that she has "collected addresses by the thousands," sound as though they had been written by an impressionable adolescent, more concerned with her appearance than her potential for achievement.

I have an airedale coat and I'm goan [sic] to New York on Monday. . . . It's a simple coat, black with blue and green stripes, . . . it has leather buttons about the size of a buckeye, made of plaited leather down the front and a full cut of sleeve and collar. It is finished with catchstitching inside and the finest quality of black satin.<sup>13</sup>

In contrast to the first letter, Moore's account of her stay, written after she had returned to Carlisle, displays self-confidence and energetic drive as well as exuberance. She describes how Alfred Kreymborg dressed and what he and his wife served her for dinner, and every detail of her visit to Alfred Steiglitz' studio and the conversations she and Kreymborg had about encouraging new writers to send their poetry to his magazine, *Others*.<sup>14</sup> It is clear that the trip gave Moore confidence that she would be able to succeed as a writer. A note Moore added to one of Mrs. Moore's letters to Warner shows that she was specifically interested in criticism.

I feel I can get a job with the [Philadelphia] *Ledger* . . . by my concentrated and cumulative exertions, am just as sure of getting it as I am of eating, if I could only see them. I am doing a couple of sample reviews. . . . and what with my poems of a critical trend in *The Egoist* and *Poetry* and *Others* and *Contemporary Verse* and my Indian experience, I should certainly extort the position. I am prepared to review poetry, fiction, art or theology. Music and sport and dancing are the only things I am afraid to tackle.<sup>15</sup>

Instead of working as a reviewer, Moore continued to write poetry and to plan for her future. In 1916, she moved with her mother to



Chatham, New Jersey, where her brother had been appointed minister at a Presbyterian church. Following shortly after Moore's exploratory sojourn, the move was clearly part of her design for a career as a poet and a critic. Only twenty-five miles from New York, Chatham offered relatively easy access to the emerging literary and artistic circles there without the radical change which a move to New York would have presented. One of Moore's letters to H.D., written shortly after Moore's move to New Jersey, displays a similar combination of ambition and cautious reserve.

I should like to try a comparison of George Moore and Fielding; also one of Knut Hamsun and Carlyle and one of Wallace Stevens and Compton Mackenzie. I am very much interested, also, in William [Carlos] Williams' work, but I am a little afraid to undertake a criticism of it. I feel that I have not seen enough of it to justify my writing one.<sup>16</sup>

The ambition and caution, determination and reserve, frivolity and meticulous attention to detail which appear here and elsewhere in Moore's early letters and notebooks continue to appear throughout her life and help to produce the work which brought her critical recognition. Just as frequently, these personality traits confounded those who met her. Out of the contrast between her astonishing work and her eccentric personality grew confused amusement, then myth, and eventually misperception. Moore's friendship with William Williams, as she insisted upon calling him for many years, represents the first state of the process. The two admired each other's work and soon became close friends. Williams tried but was unable to break through Moore's reserve. Instead, the two seem to have enjoyed and cultivated their differences. From the first they admired each other's work, and apparently Williams enjoyed playing the bohemian tempter to Moore's reserve. He once promised to drink only "sacramental wine" if Moore would attend a party with the "crowd" in which he said she seemed both in and out of place, like a red berry hanging to a jaded rose bush.<sup>17</sup> True to her adopted role and in her best documentary style, Moore answered, typing a carbon of her response on the verso of Williams' letter. She said that she recognized this difference in her manner but felt no discomfort with it since, "I cannot feel sorry for the red berry when the bush is so full of sap."

This exchange shows that Moore both assented to and participated in the image that Williams and many of his friends had constructed. For instance, Moore is invariably remembered for appearing in Alfred Kreymborg's *Troubador* as the endearing baseball fan who surprised

William Carlos Williams and Kreymborg by her knowledge of the game, but that was only part of the portrayal. He had also described Moore as "an astonishing person with Titian hair, a brilliant complexion and a mellifluous flow of polysyllables which held every man in awe."<sup>18</sup> He added that what many of their village friends "lacked in intellectual ability was freely and consciously supplied by her [and that] her familiarity with books on every conceivable subject astonished them" (pp. 186-87).

Robert McAlmon's portrait of Moore in his roman à clef, *Post Adolescence*, also seems to approach caricature, particularly in the most commonly excerpted passages which make particular note of Moore's closeness to her mother. However, her portrait deserves close attention since it turns out to be the most flattering one in the book and shows why Moore's friends thought of her as they did. McAlmon presents a complex Marianne Moore who startled her companions more by her intelligence and productivity than by her conventional or even eccentric mannerisms. The novel follows the aimless wanderings of Peter (McAlmon) who, like many of his friends, wanted mainly to "dance, sing, paint, copulate, eat, sleep, and finally die."<sup>19</sup> He portrays Vera St. Vitus (Edna St. Vincent Millay) as "a nice girl [who] doesn't use her head" (p. 92), and Gusta Rolph (Mina Loy) as "a dancer," notably chiefly for her "dandruff-tossing, eye-glistening semitic vivacity" (pp. 2-3). In contrast to these limited portrayals, Martha Wullus (Marianne Moore) appears in the novel's penultimate chapter as a complex and not easily likable person. "She thinks anything, disapproves of little for other people, and is a churchgoing cerebralizing moralist herself." Peter "can't quite understand why with a mind like hers agnosticism hasn't eaten into her a little" and thinks that he ought to be "bored to death with Martha Wullus." He isn't though, because he "can't get her angle." Peter's friend, Brander Ogden (Marsden Hartley) is hardly more encouraging, calling her a "quaint idea rather than a real human being." Peter agrees, adding that it is probably "best for her to be only an idea, too, seeing that ideas is about all she'll ever have out of life." Thus, when Peter, Brander, and Gusta decide to call on Martha and her mother at their Greenwich Village basement apartment, it is no surprise that Martha speaks too formally for the comfort of her guests. "O good day and how have all of you been, you Miss Rolph, particularly? I've so wanted to have a conversation with you because of what I've heard about your work."

The visit turned out to be a dismal one during which Martha's mother "drawled out her observations, making distinctions of her exact

meaning with a too careful honesty that had its limitations." Martha, in her world of ideas, worried that her work at the library kept her from "my work, the real kind I'm wanting to do." Gusta refused to believe this, all but accusing Martha of success. "Bother your paid work. You observe things too uniquely to let any paid job interfere with your writing. Though I presume you believe in self-discipline and duty more than some of us do." The young guests plan an escape and take Martha with them to a "dingy little bohemian cafe." In the cafe, Martha continues to speak in her elaborately formal sentences, this time on the subject of self-discipline. She admits that finding time to work is difficult, but turns that struggle into an advantage. "It's restraining oneself in the midst of annoyances to which one is subjected that toughens the muscles. Wildness in itself is an attractive quality, but it fails to take into account the question of attrition and attrition is inevitable." Martha describes her writing with equal conviction. "I'm telling you the truth when I say that if I had all the time in the world I should not write anything important to myself for some years. In order to work as I should have to, I should like to look into certain other things. That may be hard for you to realize, but it is quite true, and I have, I think, an intuition as to how I am to succeed if I do succeed" (pp. 104-19). The novel ends with Peter's self-indulgent disillusionment, made all the more painful by his reflections upon Martha's confident intuition of success.

The accuracy with which McAlmon captured the rhythm of Moore's speech and her "intuition" of success reflects her real-life comments to him on the subject. In fact, his portrayal of Moore turns out to be almost pure documentation. In 1921, three years before McAlmon published *Post Adolescence*, he had married Bryher (Winifred Ellerman) on short notice and much to the dismay of many of their friends. Williams exploits the event in his *Autobiography*, alluding to Bryher's lesbian relationship with H.D.; but Moore was unhappy for entirely different reasons. On one level, she disapproved of the suddenness of the marriage and wrote McAlmon saying so. McAlmon tried to answer Moore's criticism by insisting that he had married Bryher to rescue her from the domination of her parents and thereby give her the freedom that Americans had. He insisted, also, that marriage was a private affair, adding that as a sign of her independence Bryher was keeping her own name.<sup>20</sup> Not at all persuaded, Moore answered that such symbols were meaningless. "I think it is very nice of you to accord a woman as much freedom as she might care to have but I think a

woman's keeping her own name seems like clutching at the last straw of self-identification."<sup>21</sup> For Moore self-identification would grow out of her work rather than romance. She wanted success as a writer and believed that marriage or any relationship would distract a woman's attention away from her creative work. She explained this in a subsequent letter to Bryher and added that instead Bryn Mawr "gave me security in my determination to have what I want."<sup>22</sup>

Thus, like the contradictions which Moore so arrogantly included in her poetry, she presents a contradiction herself. Lover of order and Dürer-like precision, she often appears docile or retiring. But beneath that demeanor lies deepest feeling and unshakable determination. Both sides of the personality appear throughout Moore's work, and she invites her readers to share in the delight which this apparent puzzle presents. In "Melancthon," her thick-skinned elephant is impervious to arrows and other unwanted intrusions, but it also enjoys the sensual experience of immersing itself in the mud. "An Octopus" praises "neatness of finish" and "relentless accuracy," but within the same stanza undermines that praise by making the dangerous unpredictability of the glacier even more appealing. The speaker of "Marriage," so able to dismiss "this / institution . . . out of respect for which / one says one need not change one's mind," also acknowledges the power of the sexual passion which so controlled and confused the married people of the poem.

This two-sided approach appears throughout Moore's poetry, but the new insights drawn from Moore's private papers make it possible to look at how consistently she develops contrasting points of view within each poem. She delights not in introducing and then resolving tensions but in emphasizing the delightful impossibility of their resolution. This is particularly true in "The Steeple-Jack," which opened Moore's 1935 *Selected Poems* and all subsequent collections of her work. The poem is a tangle of brilliant images which warn that surface appearances may be misleading. Once again, some new unpublished material points toward Moore's love of confusion. Her response to a query about the setting of the poem is informative, but she seems to have enjoyed stopping short of solving the riddle completely.

C. J. Poole was a Brooklyn steeple-jack who worked on the various high buildings and steeples and had his name on the sidewalk danger sign, warning passersby to keep clear of ropes and grapnels on the sidewalks. He was repairing the steeple of the Lafayette Avenue Presbyterian Church, the steeple was finally considered infirm and was replaced by 4 Gothic points.

Dürer was interested in the whales he saw near Amsterdam; and eight whales were stranded in Brooklyn Bay.\*\* I had in mind both Brooklyn and various New England seacoast towns I had visited.

. . . . .

\*\*Or perhaps it was near Sheepshead Bay. I have somewhere a newspaper clipping about the whales and they were attracting citizens and other sightseers.<sup>23</sup>

Moore offers information—even a contradictory footnote—but not answers, details which “fail” to solve the puzzle. The letter thus intensifies rather than diminishes the unsettling complexities of the poem. “The Steeple-Jack,” itself, includes a series of surprising alterations of deliberately set expectations, made possible chiefly by Moore’s skillful use of a complex syllabic structure rather than traditional rhythmic line divisions. “Flock” in stanza two becomes a verb, not a noun as the preceding words had led us to expect, and “sea-” in stanza four becomes “sea-side flowers.” Even more insistently, the narrative itself is unsettling. The poem opens with a stanza which promises to offer an occasion for benign, nostalgic reflection. The opening exemplifies the brilliant precision one expects in a Marianne Moore poem.

Dürer would have seen a reason for living  
in a town like this, with eight stranded whales  
to look at; with the sweet sea air coming into your house  
on a fine day, from water etched  
with waves as formal as the scales  
on a fish.

But the picture-perfect day on which “you can see a twenty-five / pound lobster; and fish nets arranged / to dry,” turns out to be not very peaceful at all. The seagulls which “One by one in two’s and three’s . . . keep / flying back and forth over the town clock” are buffeted by the wind’s turbulence as a storm “bends the salt / marsh grass, disturbs stars in the sky and the / star on the steeple.” Nothing in the poem stands still or can be determined. One cannot be certain of the time of day or the perspective of the viewer. Nor is it clear why the poem’s “college student / named Ambrose sits on the hillside / with his not-native books and hat / and sees boats // at sea progress white and rigid as if in a groove.” Under this town’s picturesque facade lurk deception and imminent danger. Ambrose “knows by heart the sugar-bowl shaped summerhouse of / interlacing slats.” He also knows “the pitch of the church // spire, not true.” When Moore presents the similarly contradictory and in this case precarious experience of the poem’s

steeple-jack, she uses her tightly controlled form to show that the danger is both unexpected and absolute. In the tranquil setting:

a man in scarlet lets  
down a rope as a spider spins a thread;  
he might be part of a novel, but on the sidewalk a  
sign says C. J. Poole, Steeple-Jack,  
in black and white; and one in red  
and white says

Danger.

The church, Moore goes on to explain, “would be a fit haven” for an unlikely group—“waifs, children, animals, prisoners, / and presidents who have repaid / sin-driven // senators by not thinking about them.” In the final stanza, with the understatement that might elude a reader overly influenced by the myth of Marianne Moore, she explodes the false serenity which the poem has carefully nurtured.

It could not be dangerous to be living  
in a town like this, of simple people,  
who have a steeple-jack placing danger signs by the church  
while he is gilding the solid-  
pointed star, which on a steeple  
stands for hope.

In the same way that earlier a fine day did not exclude “the whirlwind fife and drum of the storm,” contradiction here reigns supreme. The star on the steeple is merely gilded. It is solid not at its center but at its points. It stands for hope, but only when on a steeple, in this case one which is untrue. Moore tears down our easy assurance as effectively and methodically as she had constructed it, and the poem ends by making us wonder whether Dürer really could have seen a reason for living in such a deceptively serene place. “The Steeple-Jack” reveals a Marianne Moore fascinated by brilliant precision but drawn as well to a subsurface boiling with contradiction and hidden danger. New Criticism called such contrasts balanced tensions. The precision of art was a welcome if temporary respite from the unpredictability and instability of human actions. Undeniably, Moore works within those terms; but, in doing so, she undermines New Critical assumptions about the balance of those tensions. Chaos triumphs in “The Steeple-Jack.” Craftsmanship is just as unstable as weather patterns and politicians. Nevertheless, the poem does not even suggest pessimism or defeat. Fascination with danger leads to appreciation as well.

Moore’s acknowledgment that art cannot triumph over chaos

leads to her determination to accept human limitation. This willingness to face adversity is most clear in "The Pangolin," which is, ironically, Moore's best-known poem about armoring. Moving without either warning or transition from one subject (the pangolin's armor) to another (human behavior), Moore constructs an apology for human frailty and then a celebration of accommodation to that frailty. Privacy is the secret of successful accommodation, and the pangolin is the very embodiment of privacy. The spruce-cone regularity of its decorative yet practical armor makes it a "night miniature artist engineer," yet the pangolin rejects any public recognition for this excellence. It is the pangolin's own choice that "we seldom hear of him." Having thus endorsed the pangolin's behavior, Moore turns to human accomplishments and illustrates the efficacy of privacy in the human quest to become "writing-master to this world." Self-assurance rather than fear motivates the human's armoring, just as it does the pangolin's. Moore goes on to elaborate upon the similarity by explaining that the pangolin's ingenious armor is as necessary as it is decorative. Armor sometimes "seems extra," she admits; but for this animal,

the closing ear-ridge—  
or bare ear lacking even this small  
eminence and similarly safe |

contracting nose and eye apertures  
impenetrably closable, are not.

The armor aids the pangolin in his "exhausting solitary trips through unfamiliar ground at night." On those journeys, it conserves energy and protects itself by "stepping in the moonlight, / on the moonlight peculiarly, that the outside / edges of his hands may bear the weight and save the claws // for digging." Each example of the pangolin's behavior emphasizes its efficiency and equanimity. "Serpentined about the tree," in a posture that might ordinarily suggest its intention to attack, the pangolin wisely

draws  
away from danger unpugnaciously,  
with no sound but a harmless hiss; keeping

the fragile grace of the Thomas-  
of-Leighton Buzzard Westminster Abbey wrought-iron vine,  
or  
rolls himself into a ball that has  
power to defy all effort to unroll it.

Moore describes this posture as "strongly entailed" and shows that it

works quietly but effectively. The pangolin's sting-proof scales resist outside pressures, so that it can form its own peaceful retreat or "nest of rocks closed with earth from inside, which he can thus darken." When under attack, this "Fearful, yet to be feared" animal engulfs what it can, regains its composure, and "will then walk away unhurt." Nevertheless, this thoroughly competent fighter prefers avoiding confrontation; and its ingenuity in doing so completes Moore's demonstration of its resourcefulness. "If unintruded on," the pangolin "cautiously works down the tree, helped // by his tail," that "graceful tool, as prop or hand or broom or ax, tipped like / an elephant's trunk with special skin."

In contrast to the infallible instinct of this animal, Moore presents the "simpletons [who] thought [the pangolin] a living fable / whom the stones had nourished whereas ants had done so." The folly of those human simpletons then provides the starting point for Moore's defense of "the being we call human." She begins by posing an involved question which she follows with an "answer" which seems to answer nothing at all.

If that which is at all were not forever,  
why would those who graced the spires  
with animals and gathered there to rest, on cold luxurious  
low stone seats—a monk and monk and monk—between the thus  
ingenious roof-supports, have slaved to confuse  
grace with kindly manner, time in which to pay a debt,  
the cure for sins, a graceful use  
of what are yet  
approved stone mullions branching out across  
the perpendiculars? A sailboat

was the first machine.

The cryptic "answer" shows that man, maker of monuments and inventor of sailboats, combines judicious reasoning with instinctive resourcefulness. "Slaving to make his life more sweet," he knows, like the pangolin, that he must "choose wisely how to use his strength." He makes monuments which are beautiful and which are also places of worship. Thus, in his own search for food, shelter, and security, this human animal becomes

a paper-maker like the wasp; a tractor of foodstuffs,  
like the ant; spidering a length  
of web from bluffs  
above a stream; in fighting, mechanicked  
like the pangolin.



Nevertheless, those adaptive skills cannot protect man from human emotions which leave him "capsizing in disheartenment." Nor can they negate his uncomfortable recognition of the similarity in his fellow human beings—"like does not like like that is obnoxious."

Ultimately, this vulnerable human animal triumphs by employing to his own advantage the intellect which had earlier led to his disheartenment. "Bedizened or stark naked, man, the self, the being we call human," becomes "writing master to the world." He alone can do so because "Among animals, *one* has a sense of humor." It is an attribute which conveys "everlasting vigor" and "saves a few steps." Thus, although this human animal's special qualities do not save him from being "Unignorant, modest and unemotional, and all emotion," he not only endures but rejoices. He enjoys the struggle and views it with pleasure rather than dismay. Moore's last stanza, the only self-contained one in her elaborately patterned poem, reveals this.

Not afraid of anything is he,  
and then goes cowering forth, tread paced to meet an  
obstacle

at every step. Consistent with the  
formula—warm blood, no gills, two pairs of hands and a few  
hairs—that

is a mammal; there he sits in his own habitat,  
serge-clad, strong shod, the prey of fear, he, always  
curtailed, extinguished, thwarted by the dusk, work partly  
done,

says to the alternating blaze,  
"Again the sun!  
anew each day; and new and new and new,  
that comes into and steadies my soul."

Armed in conventional clothing, this prey of fear, this intelligent animal treads forth to meet each obstacle. The emotional triumph of that human victory stands in marked contrast to the more stable but much less rewarding "not unchain-like machine-like form and frictionless creep" of the pangolin's daily endeavor. The poem celebrates both the struggle and the victory of this armored writing master.

Like most of Moore's poetry, "The Pangolin" refrains from directly autobiographical statement. The "writing master" is a "he" rather than a "she," and by way of identification we learn only that he is "serge-clad, strong shod." Nevertheless, the methodical ambition, the fearless determination, and the cautious but boundless energy of this writing master are the same qualities which appear in Moore's letters and notebooks. The portrait which emerges stands in direct contrast to those which emphasize Moore's eccentricity. Her strict control remains,

but beneath and because of it, Moore's poems explore deepest feeling with unshakable determination.

All previously unpublished material by Marianne Moore is used with the permission of Clive E. Driver, Literary Executor of the Estate of Marianne C. Moore.

<sup>1</sup> Marianne Moore, *Complete Poems* (New York: The Macmillan Company, 1981), p. 119. All quotations will be from this edition.

<sup>2</sup> Conversation with Kenneth Burke, April 23, 1982.

<sup>3</sup> R. P. Blackmur, "A Critic's Job of Work," in Hazard Adams, ed., *Critical Theory Since Plato* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, Jovanovich, 1971), pp. 903-04.

<sup>4</sup> R. P. Blackmur, "The Method of Marianne Moore," in Charles Tomlinson, ed., *Marianne Moore: A Collection of Critical Essays* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice Hall, 1969), p. 66. Subsequent references will be given parenthetically.

<sup>5</sup> John Crowe Ransom, "On Being Modern with Distinction," *Quarterly Review of Literature*, 4, 2 (1948), 136. Subsequent references will be given parenthetically.

<sup>6</sup> Roy Harvey Pearce, *The Continuity of American Poetry* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton Univ. Press, 1961), p. 369.

<sup>7</sup> Hugh Kenner, "Meditation and Enactment," in Charles Tomlinson, A *Collection of Critical Essays*, p. 13.

<sup>8</sup> George W. Nitchie, *Marianne Moore: An Introduction to the Poetry* (New York: Columbia Univ. Press, 1969), p. 174.

<sup>9</sup> Pamela White Hadas, *Marianne Moore: Poet of Affection* (Syracuse, N.Y.: Syracuse Univ. Press, 1977), p. 103.

<sup>10</sup> Hugh Kenner, *A Homemade World: The American Modernist Writers* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1975), p. xviii.

<sup>11</sup> Unpublished letter, Mary Warner Moore to Marianne Moore, 11/19/08. Unless otherwise indicated, all letters are from the Rosenbach Foundation Museum and Library.

<sup>12</sup> Marianne Moore to Mary Warner Moore, 11/15/08.

<sup>13</sup> Marianne Moore to John Warner Moore, 11/26/15.

<sup>14</sup> Marianne Moore to John Warner Moore, 12/15/15, 12/19/15 and 12/22/15.

<sup>15</sup> Marianne Moore in a note added to a letter by Mary Warner Moore to John Warner Moore, 12/15/15.

<sup>16</sup> Letter, Marianne Moore to H.D., 11/10/16.

<sup>17</sup> William Carlos Williams to Marianne Moore, 11/16/19, and Marianne Moore to William Carlos Williams, on verso.

<sup>18</sup> Alfred Kreyenborg, *Troubador: An American Biography* (New York: Sagamore Press, 1957), pp. 186-87. Subsequent references will be given parenthetically.

<sup>19</sup> Robert McAlmon, *Post Adolescence* (Paris: Contact Publishing Company, n.d.), p. 18. Subsequent references will be given parenthetically.

<sup>20</sup> Robert McAlmon to Marianne Moore, 4/12/21.

<sup>21</sup> Marianne Moore to Robert McAlmon, 6/18/21.

<sup>22</sup> Marianne Moore to Bryher, 8/31/21.

<sup>23</sup> Marianne Moore, "Letter to Barbara Kurz," *Marianne Moore Newsletter*, 1, 2 (Fall 1977), 7.